outlook at the beginning of the war. For instance, according to Mukhopadhaya, who was posted in Kabul in 2001, Karzai strongly nurtured the belief that Afghanistan was a victim of India-Pakistan rivalry.[52] The United Front, however, had disintegrated after Massoud's death two days before the 9/11 attacks happened, leaving Rabbani, Mohaqiq, Dostum, Abdullah, Ismael Khan, and Qanooni competing for ministerial positions, and coalescing behind or against Karzai. The question then was, who to support and how?

Partisans and conciliators debated this question just as vigorously as other issues on how to approach the Mujahideen and the Taliban. Though both saw the necessity of supporting Karzai in the changed context, the issue was whether this support will be symbolic or substantial? Unlike previous decades, conciliators such as Shyam Saran wanted to ensure that India did not commit the same mistake of adopting a partisan line and play political favourites. India should expand its political base and reach out to non-Taliban Pashtun leaders including Karzai, he argued. 'Those who were in positions to make decisions in 2004–05, and certainly I as foreign secretary was part of that, the sense was that it's extremely important that we have a broad-based constituency in Afghanistan', he states.[53] Partisans such as Vivek Katju, who was appointed ambassador to Kabul in 2002, however, advocated supporting former UF allies independent of Karzai. As the next section details, the partisans wanted India to offer limited support to Karzai, but remain politically aligned with the ostensibly tried-and-tested anti-Pakistan leaders and India's old 'friends' such as Abdullah and Qanooni (and other former UF officials).

Marking a subtle but substantial switch in India's Afghanistan policy, the conciliators won the day. Driven by changes in domestic Afghan politics, including Massoud's demise, as well as international pressure at Bonn, the policy shift almost went unnoticed in the early days of Karzai's presidency. The key conciliatory tenets remained the same after 2002, that is: (a) India should engage with whosoever is in power in Kabul and cultivate a friendly government sensitive to India's core interests; (b) deal strictly with the government in Kabul regardless of how its relations with Pakistan are; (c) don't adopt a selective engagement strategy, wherein preference is given to one group or community over others; (d) develop P-2-P relations and build public goodwill for India in Afghanistan. The